8 places your next client is hiding

A cheat sheet for finding local businesses that need a website. Most people only try one (Google Maps). Use three. Every source here is public. Never use an owner's personal phone, email or home address.

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1. New business licenses (be first in the door)

Most cities publish every new business license as open data, often updated daily.

- **Find it:** search `"[your city]" open data "business license"`, open the dataset, sort by issue date.
- **Good lead:** a storefront or service business that opened in the last 30 days. Skip home-based licenses, renewals and chains.
- **First move:** "Congrats on opening. I noticed you're not on Google yet / don't have a site, so I made you a preview."
- **Scale:** Chicago issued 264 new business licenses in 14 days (Oct 2026). In a spot check of 12 new shops and restaurants, 8 had no website or weren't on Google Maps.
- *Automated by the free* `find-new-businesses` *skill.*

2. Great reviews, no website (Google Maps)

- **Find it:** Google Maps › `[trade] in [town]` › look for listings with no Website button.
- **Good lead:** 20+ reviews at 4.5★ or better. Busy and trusted, missing the obvious. Check with a quick web search that they really have no site (some link Facebook instead).
- **Scale:** in our test, 32 of 115 Chicago handymen had no website (Oct 2026).
- *Automated by the free* `find-clients` *skill.*

3. Broken or outdated websites

They already paid for a website once, so they get it.

- **Look for:** domains that don't load, "Not secure" warnings, error pages, "this domain is for sale", © 2019 in the footer, no mobile layout.
- **First move:** lead with the screenshot of what their customers see today. Confirm in a real browser first: never pitch a false alarm.
- **Scale:** 10 of 70 Chicago handyman websites we checked were broken (Oct 2026).

- *Automated by the free* `find-broken-sites` *skill.*

4. Reviews that complain about the website or booking

- **Find it:** in their Google or Yelp reviews, search for "website", "book online", "couldn't find", "hours were wrong", "menu".
- **Good lead:** a recent review where a customer struggled online. The owner already knows it's a problem.
- **First move:** quote the problem (not the reviewer's name), then show the fix.

5. People asking for help online

- **Find it:** `site:reddit.com "[city]" "web designer"` (or "website"), your local Facebook groups, Nextdoor, local "gigs" listings.
- **Good lead:** a post from the last few months by a business you can identify.
- **First move:** answer the question helpfully in public first. Offer help only if it fits. No copy-paste pitches.

6. Partners who serve the same owners

Other people get asked "do you know a website person?" every week.

- **Who:** accountants and bookkeepers, insurance brokers, business bankers, sign shops, printers, photographers, commercial cleaners, local IT people.
- **First move:** "I build websites for [trade] in [area]. When your clients ask you about a website, can I be the person you send them to? Happy to send people your way too."
- **Make it easy:** a one-page referral card, and a thank-you (or a referral fee, in writing) for every client.

7. Rooms full of owners

- **Where:** chamber of commerce mixers, networking chapters (BNI and similar), trade association meetings, local business expos, a talk at the library ("Get found on Google").
- **First move:** ask about their business, not yours. Show a preview site on your phone only when they ask what you do.
- **Goal:** one real conversation and one follow-up per event.

8. Your own network (the warm 50)

In a GoDaddy survey of small business owners, 73% said they find web designers through recommendations.

- **Do it:** list 50 people you know (family, friends, old coworkers, your barber, your mechanic).
- **Ask:** "Quick one: who do you know who runs a business with no website, or an old one? I'm helping local businesses get found on Google." That's it. Don't pitch them, ask for the introduction.

The 20-in-20 routine

20 minutes a day, 20 leads in a simple sheet (name, trade, area, source, why they need it, phone, next step):

- 10 from Google Maps (source 2)
- 5 broken sites (source 3)
- 5 new licenses (source 1)

Then contact the best 5 the same day. Walk in or call before you email.

Free skills that automate sources 1 to 5: github.com/WordRocket/local-client-finder (the `client-agents` skill runs five of them at once and picks your top 3). Follow local anti-spam and calling rules (CAN-SPAM and TCPA in the US, CASL in Canada, PECR/GDPR in the UK/EU): one personal message per business, stop when they say no, no cold texting. Data: City of Chicago open data and our Google Maps checks, Oct 2026; GoDaddy "What clients want" survey. Results vary.